

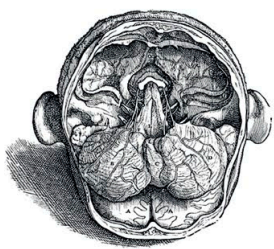
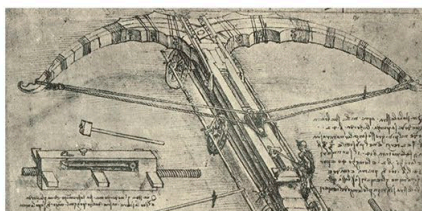
c.1400-1600

THE RENAISSANCE

During the 15th and 16th centuries, the city-states of Italy were the focus for a major flowering of the arts and new ideas. This movement is called the Renaissance as it centred around a “rebirth” of knowledge, based on the rediscovery of the thought and culture of Ancient Greece and Rome.

The material basis for the Renaissance lay in the prosperity of city-states such as Florence, Venice, and Milan, which had grown rich through trade, banking, and the manufacture of luxury goods. These cities’ ruling elites, such as the Medici family in Florence, lavishly patronized scholars, painters, sculptors, and architects. They were prepared to back innovations such as linear perspective and non-religious

subject-matter in painting, or statues that celebrated the beauty of the naked body. Successive popes in Rome, enriched by contributions from the Christian faithful, were another major source of patronage. Perhaps the single greatest Renaissance work, Michelangelo’s ceiling of the Sistine Chapel, was painted for Pope Julius II. Although the Renaissance challenged certain Christian taboos, including the ban on dissection for the study of anatomy, it saw the ideas of pagan antiquity as an adjunct to Christian faith. The spirit of free enquiry nourished by the Renaissance spread across Europe, feeding into the Protestant revolt against Catholicism and the beginnings of modern science.



KEY MOMENTS

1485 *The Birth of Venus*

This painting (left) by Florentine artist Sandro Botticelli typifies the Renaissance embrace of themes from Greek and Roman mythology. Patrons of the arts revelled in the learned allegorical detail of such works, as well as the seductive beauty of the naked goddess.

c. 1487-1510 *Da Vinci's notebooks*

Leonardo da Vinci was the total “Renaissance Man”, an inspired painter, engineer, inventor, and researcher. Working chiefly in Florence and Milan, he filled notebooks (left) with observations and innovative ideas, including designs for flying machines and weaponry.

1543 *On the Fabric of the Human Body*

Flemish physician Andreas Vesalius published the results of his dissection of corpses, mostly conducted at the University of Padua, in a book entitled *On the Fabric of the Human Body* (left). His work was a giant step forward in the understanding of human anatomy.

